



RPI Outdoor Programs and Rensselaer Outing Club

Winter Mountaineering Policies

Introduction:

Winter Mountaineering has the potential to be a dangerous activity. Due to this inherent danger, the conduct of this activity's leaders and participants must fall under the accepted scope of practice for Winter Mountaineering at RPI.

This document intends to standardize all Winter Mountaineering trips and will outline the guidelines and standards for which leaders are permitted to operate. These guidelines and standards meet or exceed industry standards and best practices commonly accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

Winter Mountaineering Trip Leaders are approved using the standards outlined in the document, including guidelines of conduct and the organization's accepted scope of practice. Components of this document incorporate leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, Trip Leader Qualifications, Trips Classifications, Approved Gear List, and Proper Trip Planning and Documentation.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

Winter Mountaineering is a term used to describe the act of climbing mountains in Winter weather conditions. An individual who engages in Winter Mountaineering must be disciplined in multiple alpine skills to accomplish their goals. The many facets of climbing mountains can leave room for interpretation and pose potential dangers for individuals, communities, and the environment. The following key considerations should be present in Winter Mountaineering programs conducted by Outdoor Programs.

Role of the Leaders:

- When facilitating a Winter Mountaineering trip, leadership needs to be established to monitor unwarranted risk on the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.
 - Leadership is defined as:
 - Assistant Winter Mountaineering Leader (i.e., Assistant Leader)
 - Winter Mountaineering Trip Leader (i.e., Trip Leader)
- Leaders of these trips need to undergo the proper leadership development and training and possess ample knowledge for the experience they are providing.
- Trip leadership must adhere to the policies and standards which provide the framework for the experience; this includes working within the accepted scope of practice.
- Trip Leaders will act professionally while considering the needs of the participant.

Risk Management:

- Trip Leaders will prioritize risk management prior to, during, and following a trip.
- Numerous factors contribute to the overall safety of all who are involved in the experience.
 - Location, weather, wildlife, terrain, equipment, physical ability, health concerns, distractions, etc., all contribute to potential risks on a program.
- At no point can Trip Leaders ensure all risk factors are eliminated. However, a leader must communicate the inherent risks involved with the activity to inform participants of potential risks.
- It is a major responsibility of a Winter Mountaineering Trip Leader to anticipate realistic risk factors and prevent exposure to the best of their ability.

Etiquette:

- Winter Mountaineering occurs in wild and remote locations that are susceptible to negative effects of misbehaved visitors. This requires proper etiquette for all who engage in Winter Mountaineering trips through Outdoor Programs.
- Leave No Trace Principles should be followed on every trip.
- Wilderness First Aid should be administered within the scope of the trip leader's abilities.
- Personal goals or trip itineraries should be replaced if another party requiring medical assistance is needed.

- All leaders and participants will abide by Challenge by Choice and Full Value Contract practices.

A “Climbing Code” by [Mountaineering: The Freedom of the Hills](#)

- A climbing party of three is the minimum unless adequate prearranged support is available.
- Rope up on all exposed places and for all glacier travel. Anchor all belays.
- Keep the party together and obey the leader or majority rule.
- Never climb beyond your ability or knowledge.
- Never let judgment be overruled by desire when choosing the route or deciding whether to turn back.
- Carry the essential clothing, food, and equipment at all times.
- Leave the trip schedule with a responsible person.
- Follow the precepts of sound mountaineering set forth in textbooks of recognized merit.
- Behave at all times in a manner that reflects favorably upon Mountaineering.

(Mountaineers, 1992)

General Program Policies:

- Trip leaders must abide by the Guiding Principles mentioned above.
- Trips are required to have at least one Trip Leader and one Assistant Leader.
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding the intended activity.
- Winter Mountaineering trips will follow the Trip Plan and GRO Submission Policy.
- Maximum participant-to-leader ratio is 6:2 on a Winter Mountaineering Trip.
- Helmets must be worn whenever technical gear is being used. (crampons, ice axes, ropes, ice climbing tools, etc.)
- Trips will not depart the campus (or trailhead in the case of previous arrival) in the event of serious inclement weather (extreme low temperature, high wind chill/speeds, travel restrictions, avalanche warnings, ice fall, etc.)
- Independent travel is prohibited on Winter Mountaineering Trips.
- All Winter Mountaineering trips will require the possession of at least one Garmin InReach device by a trip leader.

Trip Leader Qualifications:

Aspiring Trip leaders must meet the following requirements to lead Winter Mountaineering Trips as either an Assistant Trip Leader or Trip Leader.

Assistant Leader:

- Possesses current WFA and CPR/AED certifications.
- Has completed the Outdoor and Wilderness Leadership course (OWL)
- Has completed the AIARE L1 avalanche hazard management course through an approved provider
- Has participated in at least one Winter Mountaineering trip
- Currently holds an Assistant Leader or Trip Leader position in Backpacking through Outdoor Program's Backpacking Policies & Leadership.
- Can communicate effectively under stress or during exposure to harsh environments.
- Ability to read common snow features and anticipate dangers associated with snow, ice, and snowpack.
- Ability to anticipate challenges in route planning and navigation in Winter and Alpine environments.
- Have knowledge and experience of proper equipment and clothing for Winter Mountaineering.
 - o Tents:
 - Proper locations/site selection when making camp
 - Proper orientation for wind/snow protection.
 - o Stoves:
 - Fuel selection
 - Stove repair
 - Stove Dangers
- Knowledge of Winter specific technical skills
 - o Winter Survival Skills
 - o Technical and/or steep terrain traveling techniques.
 - Use of crampons
 - How to properly identify, size, and fit crampons
 - General Crampon Techniques
 - Self-Arrest with a Mountaineering Axe
 - Appropriate use of ropes and fixed lines in an alpine environment.

Trip Leader:

Winter Mountaineering Trip Leaders will have all the qualifications of an Assistant Leader as well as...

- Has participated in at least two Winter Mountaineering Trips and has been an Assistant Leader on one of those trips.
- Has passed the RPI Outdoor Programs Rock Climbing Leadership Course or another equivalent 3rd party examination.
- Has received approval from Outdoor Programs professional staff and ROC ECOMM.

Trip Classifications:

Introductory:

Introductory trips are planned to introduce students to the skills and concepts that make up Winter Mountaineering. Trips should be centered around introducing, instructing, and practicing mountaineering skills, focusing on education and not application. Trip dynamics such as ease of travel, proximity to resources, and access to rescue/aid should be factors when planning Introductory-level trips. Risks associated with avalanches, glacier travel, damaging temperatures/wind, heights, steep terrain, low visibility, thin ice, and other unforeseen risks should be intentionally avoided. Miles and elevation should be supportive of those with limited experience in backcountry travel in winter conditions.

(Suggestions: ≤ 5 miles, $\leq 1000'$ of elevation gain, little to no exposure)

Intermediate:

Trips at the Intermediate level require participants to possess previous experience and instruction in Winter Mountaineering. The use of specialized gear may be required to cover terrain. (i.e. ice axe, crampons, or ropes). Travel above the tree line is permitted in inclement weather as long as the group stays in visual and/or audible confirmation of one another. Distance and elevation are more difficult than an Introductory level trip.

(Suggestions: ≤ 12 miles, $< 3500'$ of elevation gain, exposure is easily managed)

Advanced:

An Advanced Winter Mountaineering trip is reserved for the most technically and physically demanding trips allowed by Outdoor Programs' policies. Advanced Winter Mountaineering trips may require multiple days of continuous travel, exposure to harsher weather conditions, demanding elevation gains/loss, and long traveling distances. The ratio of participants to leader is 4:2 for an Advanced Winter Mountaineering trip. A participant must have previous Winter Mountaineering experience on Introductory & Intermediate Winter Mountaineering trips and pre-approval from trip leaders

before participation in an Advanced trip. Advanced Winter Mountaineering trips require a pre-trip meeting with Outdoor Programs professional staff and all Trip Leaders before the trip may depart campus.

Approved Gear Lists:

For Participants:

- Backpack (+35L)
- Whistle
- Extra Clothing (shirt, socks, underwear, etc.)
- Extra Layers (Puffy, Belay Jacket, Fleece/Mid-layer, etc.)
- Wind/Waterproof Shell and Pants
- Winter Hat
- Gloves or Mittens
- Headlamp (w/ extra batteries)
- Snowshoes/Micro Spikes (or both)
- Trekking Poles (optional)
- Helmet (trip dependent)
- Ice Axe (trip dependent)
- Crampons (trip dependent)
- Sunglasses or Ski Goggles
- Personal Items (Medications, sunscreen, extra contacts, hand-warmers, etc.)
- Extra Food/Fuel (high calories, no need for preparation, won't spill or spoil)
- Emergency Shelter (emergency bivy or mylar/space blanket)
- Insulative pad (sleeping pad or sitting pad)

For Leaders: (Single Day)

- Backpack (+35L)
- Medical Kit
- InReach Device (1+)
- Whistle
- Map and Compass
- Copy of Trip Sheet
- Extra Food/Water
- Extra Clothing (shirt, socks, underwear, etc.)
- Extra Layers (Puffy, Belay Jacket, Fleece/Mid layer, etc)
- Water/Windproof Shell and Pants
- Headlamp (w/ extra batteries)
- Snowshoes/Micro Spikes (or both)
- Trekking Poles (optional)
- Helmet (trip dependent)
- Ice Axe (trip dependent)
- Crampons (trip dependent)
- Rope (trip dependent)
- Sunglasses or Ski Goggles
- Personal Items (Medications, sunscreen, extra contacts, hand-warmers, etc.)
- Extra Food/Fuel (high calories, no need for preparation, won't spill or spoil)
- Backpacking Stove & Extra Fuel
- Matches/Windproof Lighter
- Repair Kits (tents/stoves/snowshoes, etc.)

- Emergency Shelter (emergency bivy or mylar/space blanket)
- Insulative pad (sleeping pad or sitting pad)
- Snow probe (trip dependent)

For Overnight Trips: (*In addition to everything named above)

- Additional Warm and Waterproof Clothing
- Tent or Bivy Shelter (Weather Appropriate)
- Cold Weather Sleeping Bag.
- Extra Spare Batteries
- Extra Light Sources
- Spare Matches or Lighter
- Extra Food & Fuel for Emergencies

Proper Trip Planning and Documentation:

Pre-Trip Preparations:

Before leaving campus, all trips must submit proper trip documentation under the guidelines and protocols below. It is important to have these documents in place for the protection of the participants, leaders, and the organization. Doing so ensures compliance with programmatic policies and procedures.

Outdoor Trip Plan:

A completed Outdoor Trip Plan (OTP) must be submitted to the shared Outdoor Programs' Trip Plan folder a week before the expected departure date. Notification of trip plan submission must be communicated to the Assistant Director of Outdoor Programs. In the event of trip/itinerary changes (cancellations, additions, etc.) an updated OTP must be on file before the trip departs. By not doing so, the leaders of the trip will be asked to meet with Outdoor Programs staff, members of ECOMM, and the chair of said activity for review and course of action moving forward.

Permits:

It is unlawful for individuals to access certain lands, parks, preserves, or mountains without the possession of a granted permit. Federal, state, or local agencies may require permits to access land under their jurisdiction. There is a chance that permission is required from multiple levels of these agencies, which could complicate the permitting process. It is the responsibility of the individuals who facilitate Winter Mountaineering programs to ensure they are permitted to use the land in the intended way.

Waivers:

Every individual involved in an OP or ROC program needs to have an RPI Outdoor Programs Assumption of Risk/Informed Consent Release on file before the start of the program. These waivers allow the participant to make an informed decision about whether they want to participate in the program. Waivers highlight the foreseeable risks related to the activity and outline anticipated conduct and expectations of participants.

Fees:

If fees are to be collected for any purpose, students need to fill out a Change/Payment/Adjustment sheet and submit it to OP.